nesses that failed. At various times he's had a chain of bookstores, a suburban produce market, an engineering consulting firm, and a mail-order catalog. He drove them all into the ground. He finally stopped creating companies and started showing others how to avoid the mistakes he made. He now works with entrepreneurs, helping them with "anything they're bad at." He seems to have found a niche. He works two weeks a month and hauls in close to half a million dollars a year. His stock options alone are enough to make a Silicon Valley junkie green with envy.

Chambers lives in Southern California with his wife, four sons, and enough off-road vehicles to keep a Boy Scout troop amused for decades. During his off weeks each month, he and his sons race around the grounds of their Laguna Hills mansion in clouds of fumes and dust.

Chambers can rattle off ideas for exciting new ventures as easily as most of us tell time. He may be playing pool in his billiard room, flying his antique Piper Cub, or polishing his Honda 1000 when an idea hits him. One day he was staining a table in his basement when he told me, "The next generation will be digital X-ray machines. Digital images are sharp and precise, far better than the dull, fuzzy, shadowy X-ray photos we're used to. Imagine what a surgeon could learn from a clear, detailed picture of a brain tumor and its surrounding tissue. The machines would be cheaper and safer than anything on the market today. Doctors would have small ones in their offices. Hospitals would have fancy ones for more complicated shots." Once Chambers has the germ of an idea, he moves to the details: how to get the best technology; how to test a prototype; why doctors would go nuts over the thing.

By the time he's finished, I'm clutching my checkbook, desperate to go out and try it.

One day I asked Chambers if he ever worries about someone stealing his ideas. He shook his head. "To turn a good idea into a business you need two things: capital and time.